

## The Complete Financial Guide for Young Couples

she said, "I think this budget is a little too restrictive. He gives me 50 cents a week for soft drinks. But I have to bring back a crushed can to get another 50 cents."

Well, I also thought that budget was a little too restrictive, so I asked Keith, "Would you mind if I took a look?"

"No," he said. He was quite proud of it.

Normally we use a very simple workbook that helps a family to budget, because I've found that the simplest budget is the best. I have an eight-foot counseling table in my office on which Keith laid out *his* budget. He unfolded it and unfolded it an unfolded it. It lapped over my eight-foot table, both length and width. It certainly was a detailed plan! He had plotted out everything they were going to spend for five years, down to five cents. Every item was budgeted including one labeled, "Free money for my wife, 50 cents per week."

"Well, that's really interesting," I observed. "What's the last item down here, miscellaneous cash?"

"Well, that's travel money for me."

I asked, "Well, how much is that?"

"About \$75 a week."

"Don't you think there's a disparity there somewhere? She gets 50 cents per week and you get \$75 per week."

"Yes, but I travel and I need expense money."

I said, "Oh, I see. Your company doesn't pay for your travel."

"Oh, sure they do."

"And don't they pay for your lunches?"

"Yes, they pay for my lunches."

"Well, where is this \$75 going?" I asked.

"Well, it's going into bowling, and I like to do some fishing."

"My friend," I said, "it doesn't work that way. You've created a unilateral budget. It works well for one person. Do you know how long you're going to keep Laura on that budget? About three months. And then she will suffer what I call the 'Custer' syndrome. Do you know what that means? CHARGE! No one can live on that kind of a budget. It's doomed to failure."